

The Last Train Home

Book 6 of 10

*She missed the last train. And found something she
was not looking for.*

CEFR Level A1 | Adult Graded Reader

Setting: A quiet train station in England, late at night.

Genre: Light Drama / Encounter

Characters

- Leila - 26. Literature student. Tired and a little anxious.
- Sam - 34. Engineer. Calm, practical, good with silences.

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Leila runs. Her bag hits her side with every step. Her hair is in her face. She reaches the platform. She looks up at the board. 22:47 - DEPARTED. The last train. Gone. The platform is empty. The night is cold. One bench. One light. A vending machine that is not working. Leila sits on the bench and looks at the empty tracks.

Leila takes out her phone. Battery at three per cent. She calls her flatmate - no answer. She calls her mother - no answer. She opens a map application. It crashes. The phone is dead. She looks at the station. The ticket office is closed. The doors to the waiting room are locked. She is alone. In a town she does not know. At eleven at night.

Leila hears footsteps. A man walks onto the platform - tall, dark jacket, bag over his shoulder. He looks at the board. He sees 22:47 - DEPARTED. He says one word, quietly. Not a nice word. Then he sits on the other end of the bench. They do not look at each other. Two strangers. One bench. One dead train.

After five minutes the man speaks. 'Did you miss it too?' 'Yes.' 'Which train?' 'The nine

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Leila misses the last train home.

forty-seven. I was on the bus from the university. It was late.' The man nods. 'I was on the bus from the conference. Also late.' He pauses. 'I am Sam.' 'Leila.' They are quiet again. But it is a different quiet - not uncomfortable.

A man in an orange jacket appears from a door at the end of the platform. 'You two know the last train is gone, right?' 'Is there a taxi?' 'One taxi in this town. Stops at eleven.' He looks at his watch. 'It is eleven fifteen.' 'A hotel?' 'There is the Kings Arms on the High Street. Ten-minute walk. Turn left at the gate.' He goes back inside.

They walk out of the station together. The street is empty. The shops are closed. Sam uses his phone map. 'Left here.' Their footsteps are loud in the quiet night. 'What do you study?' 'Literature. I am writing my thesis on Thomas Hardy.' Sam is quiet for a moment. 'I know Hardy. The Return of the Native. I read it at school.' 'Did you like it?' 'No,' Sam says. But he smiles.

The hotel is a small pub with rooms. An old man is behind the bar reading. 'We need two rooms.' 'Married?' 'No,' they say at the same time. The old man nods. 'Two rooms. Thirty-five pounds each. Breakfast is at eight.' 'Perfect.' Sam pays first.

Leila pays second. 'You can pay me back - I saw your phone die.' Leila is embarrassed but grateful.

They come back downstairs. The bar is quiet - two older men playing cards. Leila has tea. Sam has a beer. 'Why do you not like Hardy?' 'He is too sad. Everyone suffers. Nothing works out.' 'That is life,' Leila says. 'Sometimes,' Sam says. 'But not always.' 'You are an optimist.' 'I am an engineer. I build things that work.'

They talk for two hours. Sam tells her about his work - bridges, mostly. He travels a lot. Leila tells him about her thesis. About Hardy and the moors and the idea of home. 'Hardy's characters always want to go back. But when they go back, it is different.' Sam is quiet. 'My home town is in the north. I go back sometimes. It is not the same.' 'Different how?' 'I am different,' he says.

The old man calls last orders at midnight. They finish their drinks and stand up. 'This was good,' Leila says. 'Unexpected. But good.' 'Yes,' Sam says. They stand at the top of the stairs. Their rooms are in opposite directions. 'Goodnight, Leila.' 'Goodnight, Sam.' She goes left. He goes right. Leila opens her room door. She sits on the bed. She thinks about bridges.

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Leila and Sam begin a quiet late-night conversation.

In the morning, Sam is already at breakfast when Leila comes down. She sits across from him. 'Sleep well?' 'Better than I expected.' They eat. The old man brings scrambled eggs. 'First train is at nine twelve,' Sam says. 'Same direction?' 'No. You go east. I go north.' Leila nods. She drinks her coffee.

They walk to the station. The morning is cold and grey. The platform is busy now. Sam's train comes first. He picks up his bag. 'It was good to meet you.' 'Yes. Thank you - for the room, for last night.' 'You would do the same,' he says. She is not sure that is true. But she does not say so. 'Leila,' he says. He pauses. He takes out his phone.

'Can I give you my number? Not - I don't mean-' He stops. Leila smiles. 'Yes. Of course.' He reads it out. She types it into her phone - she charged it at the hotel. 'If you ever need someone to talk about bridges and Thomas Hardy,' he says. Leila laughs. A real laugh. 'Deal,' she says. His train comes in. He gets on. The doors close. The train moves. Leila watches it go.

Leila's train is the 9:12. She sits by the window. The countryside moves past - green fields, trees, small houses. She thinks about last night. The cold

platform. The walk. The bar. The conversation. She thinks about what Sam said: I am different. She opens her notebook. Not for her thesis - just her own words. She writes for the whole journey.

On Monday, Leila's supervisor reads her latest thesis chapter. 'Something is different here. The writing is stronger. More personal.' 'I had an interesting weekend,' Leila says. 'Good. Keep this.' The supervisor points at the page. 'This is the real you.' Leila walks out. She looks at her phone. Sam's number is there. She does not call. Not yet. But she does not delete it either.

Three weeks later, Leila is stuck on her thesis chapter. The words are wrong. The argument is weak. She opens a new message and types: 'Hi. It is Leila. From the train station. I am stuck on Hardy. Can I ask you something strange?' She reads it five times. She sends it. Then she closes her eyes.

Sam replies in ten minutes. 'Hi Leila. Of course. What is the question?' She writes: 'Hardy says people cannot escape their background. Do you think that is true?' A pause. Then: 'I think you can build something new. But you cannot erase the old. It is like a bridge - the old structure is still

under the new one.' Leila reads this. She opens her thesis document. She starts to write.

Leila finishes the chapter in four hours. It is the best thing she has ever written. She sends it to her supervisor. Then she writes to Sam. 'Thank you. You just wrote my thesis chapter. Well - I wrote it. But you gave me the bridge.' Sam replies: 'You are welcome. How is it going?' They write back and forth for an hour. Not about Hardy. About other things.

In December, Sam's work takes him near Leila's university. 'Coffee?' he writes. 'Yes,' she writes. They meet at a café near the river on a Tuesday afternoon. Sam is the same - quiet, direct, interested. Leila is different from the girl on the platform - less anxious, more sure of herself. They talk for three hours. The bridge conversation is still the best one. But this is very good too.

That evening at the station, Sam checks the board. 'Last train to London is at ten forty-five.' Leila checks hers. 'Mine is ten thirty.' They stand on the platform. 'Don't miss it,' Sam says. He is smiling. 'I won't,' Leila says. She is smiling too. Her train comes. She looks at him through the window. He waves once. She waves back. The

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At sunrise, they walk together with new hope.

train moves. She looks forward. She is not anxious. She is not afraid. She is going home - and home is a little bigger than before.

Story Vocabulary

The words below are collected from the story. They are given together so the reading pages stay like a real story book.

1. platform	peron	2. departed	kalkmış
3. bench	bank	4. vending machine	otomat
5. tracks	raylar	6. battery	pil
7. flatmate	ev arkadaşı	8. crashes	çöküyor
9. dead	ölü (telefon)	10. ticket office	bilet gişesi
11. footsteps	ayak sesleri	12. shoulder	omuz
13. other end	diğer ucu	14. strangers	yabancılar
15. conference	konferans	16. pauses	duraksar
17. uncomfortable	rahatsız edici	18. university	üniversite
19. orange jacket	turuncu ceket	20. shrugs	omuz silker
21. Kings Arms	otel adı	22. turn left	sola dön
23. empty	boş	24. thesis	tez
25. nineteenth century	on dokuzuncu yüzyıl	26. surprised	şaşırmış
27. smiles	gölümser	28. pub	pub
29. married	evli	30. at the same time	aynı anda
31. embarrassed	utanmış	32. grateful	minnettar
33. downstairs	aşağıya	34. beer	bira
35. suffers	acı çeker	36. works out	yoluna girer
37. optimist	iyimser	38. bridges	köprüler
39. mostly	çoğunlukla	40. moors	ıssız açık araziler

41. idea of home	ev fikri	42. different	farklı
43. last orders	son sipariş	44. midnight	gece yarısı
45. unexpected	beklenmedik	46. opposite directions	zıt yönler
47. sleep well	iyi uyumak	48. expected	beklediğim
49. scrambled eggs	çırpılmış yumurta	50. east	doğu
51. busy	kalabalık	52. picks up	alır
53. give you my number	numaranı vermek	54. charged	şarj etti
55. deal	anlaştık	56. watches it go	gidişini izler
57. countryside	kırsal	58. fields	tarlalar
59. her own words	kendi kelimeleri	60. whole journey	tüm yolculuk
61. supervisor	tez danışmanı	62. chapter	bölüm
63. stronger	daha güçlü	64. personal	kişisel
65. delete	silmek	66. stuck	takılmış
67. argument	argüman	68. weak	zayıf
69. strange	garip	70. closes her eyes	gözlerini kapar
71. escape	kaçmak	72. background	geçmiş, köken
73. erase	silmek	74. structure	yapı
75. starts to write	yazmaya başlar	76. finishes	bitirir
77. gave me the bridge	köprüyü sen verdin	78. back and forth	karşılıklı
79. other things	başka şeyler	80. direct	doğrudan

81. anxious	endişeli	82. less anxious	daha az endişeli
83. sure of herself	kendinden emin	84. checks	kontrol eder
85. don't miss it	kaçırma	86. waves once	bir kez el sallar
87. looks forward	ileriye bakar	88. a little bigger	biraz daha büyük

After-Reading Activities

1. Vocabulary Practice - Match the Words

Match each word with the correct meaning.

1. platform
- A. boş
2. empty
- B. peron
3. anxious
- C. endişeli
4. grateful
- D. beklenmedik
5. unexpected
- E. minnettar
6. erase
- F. kaçmak
7. escape
- G. silmek
8. direct
- H. doğrudan

2. Fill in the Blanks

Choose the correct word from the box and write it in the blank.

missed - grateful - stuck - anxious - bridge - thesis

1. Leila _____ the last train because the bus was late.
2. Sam paid for her hotel room and she was _____.
3. Leila is writing her _____ on Thomas Hardy.
4. Three weeks later, she is _____ on her chapter.
5. Sam says: the old structure is still under the new one - like a _____.
6. At the start, Leila is _____. At the end, she is not.

3. Comprehension Questions

True or False? Write T or F.

1. Leila misses her train because she is late from work. ____
2. Sam is a doctor. ____
3. They stay at a hotel called the Kings Arms. ____
4. They talk about Thomas Hardy at the bar. ____
5. Leila and Sam take the same train in the morning. ____
6. Leila's supervisor says her writing is stronger after the weekend. ____

Short Answer Questions

7. What is the problem with Leila's phone at the station?
8. How do they find out about the hotel?
9. What does Sam think about Thomas Hardy?
10. What does Sam mean when he says "I am different"?
11. Why does Leila message Sam three weeks later?
12. What does Sam say about bridges that helps Leila?
13. What does Leila's supervisor say about the new chapter?
14. Where do Leila and Sam meet in December?
15. What does the last line mean?

Answer Key

(Alıştırmaları yaptıktan sonra bakınız.)

Match: 1-B 2-A 3-C 4-E 5-D 6-G 7-F 8-H

Fill in the Blanks: 1. missed 2. grateful 3. thesis 4. stuck 5. bridge 6. anxious

True / False: 1. F 2. F 3. T 4. T 5. F 6. T

7. The battery is at three per cent, then the phone dies.

8. The station worker tells them about the Kings Arms on the High Street.

9. He thinks Hardy is too sad - everyone suffers and nothing works out.

10. He means he has changed over the years, not that the place changed.

11. She is stuck on her thesis chapter and wants to ask Sam a question.

12. He says you can build something new but you can't erase the old - like a bridge.

13. She says the writing is stronger and more personal.

14. At a café near the river, close to her university.

15. Her world has grown - the missed train brought new connections and confidence.